

Module 8: How to create plans

Deep dive on creating plans and fundraising for it

Week 4 | Online-Synchronous | Friday

This module addresses one of the most consequential skills in advocacy: the ability to **translate ethical commitments and analytical insight into plans that are credible, defensible, and accountable**. Planning is often misunderstood as a bureaucratic step that follows conviction. In reality, planning is where conviction is tested. It is the point at which values meet constraint, and where intentions are forced to confront trade-offs, uncertainty, and the distribution of risk.

For advocates working on complex, politically charged issues such as food systems and farmed animal protection, the quality of planning directly affects not only effectiveness, but legitimacy.

Planning as an Ethical Practice

Throughout this fellowship, you have engaged with questions of scale, neglect, welfare, rights, and justice. Planning is where these questions become operational. Every plan—whether explicit or implicit—answers a set of moral and strategic questions:

- *Which harms are we prioritising, and why?*
- *Which actors do we believe have the capacity to change?*
- *What assumptions are we making about incentives, resistance, and feasibility?*
- *Who bears the cost if we are wrong?*

Poorly articulated plans do not merely fail to achieve impact. They risk:

- misallocating scarce resources,
- externalising harm onto vulnerable communities, and
- undermining trust between advocates, partners, and the public.

For this reason, planning should be treated as a **form of moral seriousness**, not administrative compliance.

Planning Under Uncertainty

A central premise of this module is that **plans are hypotheses about change, not guarantees of success**. In complex social systems, outcomes are uncertain, feedback is delayed, and interventions often have unintended consequences. Responsible planning does not deny this reality. It makes it visible. Good plans:

- state their assumptions clearly,
- identify where uncertainty lies, and
- define what would count as evidence that those assumptions are wrong.

This orientation shifts planning from prediction to learning.

The Capstone as a Planning Exercise

The capstone template you will use reflects how advocacy initiatives are assessed in professional settings, including by partner organisations, institutions, and funders. Its structure is deliberate. Each section exists to counter a common failure mode in advocacy planning. The first critical distinction lies between **describing a problem** and **justifying why it should be prioritised**.

Section 2: Problem Definition — Describing Reality Without Argument

The purpose of the Problem Definition is to **describe what is happening**, not to persuade. At this stage, you are expected to state clearly:

- the concrete harm, gap, or failure you are addressing, and
- who or what is affected, including animals, people, institutions, or systems.

This section should avoid:

- moral evaluation,
- claims about urgency, or
- arguments about why others should care.

Its role is to establish a **shared, bounded understanding of reality**. Strong problem definitions are:

- specific rather than totalising,
- precise rather than rhetorical, and
- legible to someone outside your immediate advocacy community.

If a problem cannot be described plainly, it cannot be addressed responsibly.

Section 3: Why This Problem Matters — Making Priorities Explicit

Only after the problem is clearly described does planning move to evaluation. This section explains **why this particular problem deserves attention relative to others**, using analytical tools and themes introduced throughout the fellowship. Here, you may draw on:

- **Scale, Neglectedness, and Solvability** to assess comparative importance;
- **Welfare and rights frameworks** to clarify the ethical stakes and limits of reform; and
- **Intersectional considerations**, including links to justice, health, environmental impact, and labour conditions.

The goal is not to list frameworks, but to demonstrate **reasoned prioritisation**. Strong justifications answer:

- *Why this problem?*
- *Why in this context?*
- *Why at this moment?*

Section 4: Objectives and Key Results: Direction Before Commitment

Once priority is established, planning moves to **direction-setting**. **Objectives** articulate the **direction of change** your project aims to contribute to. They are qualitative and aspirational, but bounded.

Key Results identify **signals that movement toward that direction may be occurring**. They are observable or verifiable, but not promises. This distinction allows for learning even when outcomes fall short. It also prevents premature over-commitment in uncertain contexts.

Section 5: Choosing an Intervention Pathway

Every plan rests on an implicit theory of power and influence. Different problems require different mechanisms. Treating all interventions as interchangeable is a common planning error. Selecting an intervention pathway forces you to answer:

- *Who needs to behave differently for this problem to change?*
- *What mechanisms could plausibly influence that behaviour?*

- *Why this pathway rather than another?*

Section 6: Theory of Change: Exposing Causal Logic

A [theory of change](#) makes your assumptions explicit. Rather than listing activities, you explain:

- why those activities should matter,
- under what conditions they would fail, and
- what must be true for success to occur.

This transparency allows others to interrogate, refine, or challenge your reasoning.

Section 7: SMART Goals: Committing With Honesty

SMART Goals translate strategy into **bounded commitments**. These goals are not meant to capture everything you care about. They are meant to reflect what your group can responsibly commit to given its capacity and constraints. They define:

- what you will attempt,
- within what timeframe, and
- at what minimum level of success.

Section 8: Activities, Outputs, and the Limits of Action

Activities are what you do. Outputs are what those activities produce. Neither is equivalent to impact.

Strong plans resist the temptation to conflate:

- effort with effectiveness, or
- visibility with change.

This distinction is central to learning-oriented advocacy.

Section 9: Risks, Constraints, and Ethical Responsibility

All advocacy creates risk. Ignoring risks does not eliminate them; it transfers their consequences to those with the least power. Responsible plans identify:

- political and institutional resistance,
- economic or social risks to affected communities,
- legal or safety concerns, and

- internal coordination challenges.

Section 10: Resources, Budgets, and Trade-offs

Budgets are expressions of values. Realism matters more than precision. Even at a high level, resource planning reveals:

- which forms of labour are valued,
- which activities are prioritised, and
- what trade-offs are accepted.

Section 11: Collective Planning and Group Responsibility

Because the capstone is completed in groups of 5–7, coordination is not incidental—it is central to the learning. Clear roles, shared expectations, and explicit accountability reduce internal friction and make collective action possible. Many advocacy initiatives fail internally before encountering external opposition.

Planning, Review, and Seed Grant Considerations

Planning standards overlap with funding standards. Groups intending to submit their capstone for **Seed Grant review** must ensure alignment with the Seed Grant Guidelines, including eligibility, scope, allowable costs, and accountability expectations. The capstone template provides a foundation, not a guarantee of funding.

Reflection: Learning to Plan Responsibly

Please reflect briefly:

1. Where did your group find it hardest to separate description from justification?
2. Which assumption in your plan feels most uncertain, and why?
3. What would make your plan credible to someone outside this fellowship?